“Wait—don’t move,” said Arun, his voice low but steady.

Maya froze mid-step. She was a young woman in her early twenties, sharp-eyed, with a restless kind of energy that made it hard for her to stay still even in dangerous moments. “Why?” she whispered. “It’s just a hallway.”

“It’s never *just* anything with him,” Arun replied.

Arun was older—mid-forties, broad-shouldered, with a tired face that carried years of caution. He wasn’t scared easily, but he *respected* fear.

From behind them, a small voice piped up.

“I don’t like this place.”

They both turned. Riya, a child no older than eight, stood clutching a stuffed rabbit. Her hair was messy, her eyes wide, and her bravery was the kind children have—the kind that trembles but doesn’t break.

Maya softened immediately. “Hey… it’s okay,” she said gently, crouching down. “We’ll be out soon.”

“That’s what you said before,” Riya replied.

Arun let out a quiet breath. “She’s right.”

Maya shot him a look. “Not helping.”

“I’m not here to *help feelings*, Maya. I’m here to keep us alive.”

A voice echoed from the far end of the hallway.

“Well, that’s comforting.”

All three stiffened.

From the shadows stepped an old man—thin, slightly hunched, with silver hair and a calm, almost amused expression. His eyes, however, were sharp. Too sharp.

Maya stood up quickly. “Who are you?”

“Someone who’s been here longer than you,” the old man said. “Much longer.”

Riya moved closer to Arun. “I don’t like him.”

“Good instinct,” Arun muttered.

The old man chuckled. “The child sees clearly. That’s rare.”

“Answer the question,” Maya said, her tone firm now. “Who are you?”

The man tilted his head. “Names don’t matter much here. But if it helps… you can call me Dev.”

“Okay, Dev,” Arun said, stepping slightly in front of the others. “What is this place?”

Dev smiled faintly. “A test.”

Maya groaned. “It’s always a test. Why is it always a test?”

“Because,” Dev said, “people reveal themselves when they think something is at stake.”

Riya tugged Arun’s sleeve. “I want to go home.”

Arun’s expression softened for a moment. “We will.”

Dev watched that exchange closely. “Interesting,” he murmured. “You protect. She questions. The child trusts, but fears. A very balanced group.”

“Stop analyzing us,” Maya snapped. “Just tell us how to leave.”

Dev’s smile faded slightly. “You already know how.”

“Clearly we don’t,” Arun replied.

Dev pointed down the hallway. “One of you walks forward. Alone.”

Silence.

Riya shook her head immediately. “No.”

Maya crossed her arms. “That’s a terrible idea.”

Arun didn’t speak right away. He just stared down the hallway.

Dev continued, “Only one can pass at a time. The others… must wait.”

“And what happens to the one who goes?” Maya asked.

Dev’s eyes flickered. “That depends on who they are.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the only one you’ll get.”